

The End of the World

The bright white light that broke through the pitch black of the isolated room, suddenly turned off. The darkness enveloped the room around him, the only light coming from the screens in front of him. One of the screens showed a tall figure standing in the hallway. Its hunched and mangled frame slowly stepped forward toward the door. As it did, he quickly stood up and ran behind a pile of boxes. He peeked his head out to see the closed door from which he was so desperately hiding from. There was a faint knock on the door. He covered his mouth and shot his head down. His beating heart drowned out the ambient noise of the building and he closed his eyes in fear.

A loud bang on the door cut through his ears and he curled up into a shivering ball. Another bang came and soon the sound of fists repeatedly smashing themselves against the cold metal door rocked the room. Tears began to roll down his cheeks as the feeling of utter helplessness overtook him and pinned him in place. With each increasingly heavy breath he took, he took in large breathfulls of hot steam that stung his mouth and throat.

The banging suddenly stopped. Heavy footsteps sounded out from just outside the door, slowly getting more quiet as they continued. As the sound of heavy footsteps faded away, the light turned on once more. He slowly uncurled from his position on the floor and stood up, his shaky and malnourished body threatening to collapse under the weight of his own fear. He walked over to the wall of screens between the boxes and the metal door, sitting down in the small office chair. The figure was now shown on camera three, hobbling away from the room.

He grabbed his head and closed his eyes, tear drops continuing to roll down his painfully thin cheeks. He slowly raised his head once more. According to the screens, the door he needed to get to was in the northernmost hallway. He was currently in the southernmost room. The figure slowly shambled down the southern hallway before turning into the kitchen. His breathing quickened. He would need to run straight down the hallway until reaching the dining area, then continue down the west hallway, go through the control room until he reached the north hallway, then make a mad dash for the door.

The figure was in the kitchen in the north hallway. If he was able to sneak past it, there would be nothing stopping him from making it to the door. He pushed the idea of it being faster than him out of his head and slowly stood up. He walked over to the door and paused. His feeble heart pounded with all its might, trying to push him back into the chair to wait for help, but he knew help was not coming.

He punched in a four number combination on the keypad next to the door and turned the doorknob after hearing a familiar click, slowly swinging the door forward. The metal door scraped the ground and his heart stopped. He quickly looked back to the kitchen camera only to see the image of an empty kitchen. He turned once more to look out the door and down the hall: the figure was standing mere yards away, staring right at him.

He slammed the door shut and the creature's heavy footsteps rushed towards the door at what sounded like inhuman speed. The light above shut off and the sound of banging fists on the now locked door sent him running back behind the boxes. He ducked behind the cover of three stacked boxes and laid down on the floor. The banging continued for much longer than normal, as did the pounding of his heart against the cold stone floor.

The banging on the door slowly calmed and he heard the sound of heavy footsteps slowly walking away. His heartbeat began to slow back down as he calmed himself. He took a few deep breaths before suddenly coming to a realization. He looked up to the still darkened light bulb. He slowly peeked up from behind the boxes to see the small empty room and the closed metal door. His focus shifted to the wall of screens on his left. Camera one showed the end of the southernmost hallway, and the figure standing in front of the metal door leading to his room. The sound of progressively quieter footsteps continued as the creature simply stood there, unmoving. The sound of the footsteps faded out of existence, the only sound left was the pounding of his own heart, and the quiet shaking of his weak body.

The pounding suddenly reappeared as the figure slammed its broken and misshapen hands on the metal door in an attempt to break it down. He covered his head once more and closed his eyes, praying for an end to this.

The figure eventually gave up and shambled back down the hallway, walking back into the kitchen. He tried to rub away tears of fear as he slowly made his way to the chair. The figure slowly made its way to the back of the kitchen and into the walk-in pantry beyond. The figure looked up at the overabundance of food stacked high on shelves that threatened to collapse under its weight. Cans of preserved fruit, packages of dried meat, bags of rice and beans stuffed to the brim. The figure turned its head and looked up at the camera. It was mocking him.

The pain of days without food gnawed at his stomach much harder than before and he clenched his fists. There was a bathroom just barely down the hall where he could hide if he was fast enough. The figure continued to stare into the camera as he stepped toward the metal door. He took a few deep breaths and readied himself before punching in the four number code once more.

The door swung open and quickly shut, locking both him and the figure out, as he ran down the hall and into the bathroom. Just as he stepped behind the bathroom wall, pounding footsteps rushed out of the kitchen and to the metal door so fast it seemed as if everything but the creature moved in slow motion. The figure banged and scratched on the metal door and he shrunk back into the dark bathroom. The only visible light appeared to come from down the hall. He held his hand over his mouth but kept his eyes open, watching the figure's every move.

The figure began to calm down and it turned away from the door. As it did he held his breath, it felt as if his heart had stopped. The figure continued down the hallway and the sound of its footsteps slowly quieted. He slowly lowered his hand and let out a silent breath. He began to crawl forward but stopped suddenly. He shrunk back into the wall leading out into the hallway. He waited for what felt like minutes until he heard a bang against the wall that shook him to the

core. Pounding footsteps sounded throughout the hall and slowly faded away. As they did, lights in the bathroom and the hallway just outside flickered on.

He slowly peeked his head out of the bathroom to see an empty hallway, lit with bright ceiling lights. He took a few steps into the hallway and reached the kitchen door. The lights inside were on, so he continued slowly down the hallway. As he reached the dining area, its bright lights flickered and his heart leapt into his throat. He stopped moving and his whole body shivered. There were three doors from the dining area, the one he had come through leading to the southernmost hall, another leading to the storage rooms, and one to the west leading to the control room. The western hallway's lights were out.

He looked over to the doorway next to him and slowly crept in. If memory served him correct there was a way to go from the storage rooms to the lounge, and from there he could get to the north hallway. As he continued down the hallway, he heard the sound of pounding footsteps behind him and the dining area's lights shut off. He ran into one of the storage rooms and hid behind a stack of cardboard boxes. The hallway light shut off, as did the light to the storage room he was in. The figure ran down the hallway and suddenly stopped. It took a few steps back toward the room he was in, and his body stiffened.

The figure stepped into the storage room and looked around. He felt like covering his chest with his hands so the figure could not hear his pounding heart, but he did not want to take his hands from his shivering mouth. The figure took a few steps further into the room and looked in one of the piles of boxes. It shoved its mangled and broken hand in before pulling it out, now holding a large, heavy wrench. The figure swung the wrench upwards, shattering the light above. It ran out of the room and down the hall. The sound of shattering glass could be heard just outside as it continued towards the lounge. Light emanated from the dining area and he quickly ran out into the hall.

There was no more use in being stealthy; if the figure broke all of the lights he would be helpless. He continued into the dining area and down the west hallway toward the control room. He reached the steam filled room, crowded with multitudes of machines with flashing buttons and dials and continued north. He ran up to the northernmost hallway, his heart beating out of his chest, before stopping. The hallway's light was off, and the sound of shattering glass rang out. He ran back into the control room and hid behind one of the machines as the figure ran into the north hallway and shattered the light. As it did so the control room's light turned dark. The figure ran into the control room and swung the heavy wrench, shattering one of the only lights left. The figure never stopped moving, continuing down the hallway toward the dining area, not noticing him.

As the figure ran out of the room he ran toward the exit. It was mere feet away and he reached out to the keypad on its side. The metal doors slid open as he slammed himself into them. Pounding footsteps sounded out from behind as the figure ran after him but the doors slammed shut, locking it out. He took a second to catch his breath before looking up into the dark and steamy room he had entered.

The room he was in was completely dark with the exception of two large red buttons, a dim and tinted light shining out from behind each one. A woman, similarly feeble and malnourished, sat below one of the buttons, looking up eagerly once he entered the room. The woman and him exchanged glances, the satisfaction clear on her face. The woman slowly stood up, resting her body on the wall to support her weight. He walked over to the other button as she put her hand on the button next to her. They looked at each other and smiled as they pressed the launch buttons simultaneously.

They heard the sound of rumbling echo throughout the building and the figure pound repeatedly on the metal door with all its might, a last ditch attempt to stop what the two had just done. They could hear screaming coming from outside the building in the far distance, along with the sound of the missile they had just blasted into the sky above.

This was the end of the world.